INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #4 · PARENTS

“I have to earn my parents' love.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Where affection was given for achievement and withdrawn for failure, children learn that love is a wage. Praise for grades, sports, or good behavior, and coldness for mistakes, teach that we are loved for what we do. As adults we may still perform for parents, or for others, hoping the reward will finally come.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, “God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.” He says, “For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works.” John writes, “We love because He first loved us.” God’s love is given before we do anything, and it is not taken back when we fail. A parent’s conditional love is a wound, but it does not set the terms for how God loves you, and you do not have to keep paying a debt you never owed.

> *“But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us”* (Romans 5:8).

Also see

> “For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast” (Ephesians 2:8–9).

> “We love because He first loved us” (1 John 4:19).

> “Though my father and mother forsake me, the LORD will receive me” (Psalm 27:10).

> “The LORD your God is among you; He is mighty to save. He will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love; He will rejoice over you with singing” (Zephaniah 3:17).

Common self-statements

- If I stop achieving, they will stop caring.
- Love is something I have to deserve.
- I have to keep proving myself.
- When I fail, I lose their love.
- I must make them proud.
- Their love is always one mistake away.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting loss of love if I stop performing.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing love as either earned or absent.
- Should statements: Insisting that I must keep earning their approval.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling anxious about failing and treating it as proof of risk.

Challenging questions

- When did I first learn that love had a price?
- What happened when I failed or disappointed them?

- If their love really is conditional, whose problem is that?
- What is the difference between earning love and receiving it?
- How did God love me before I did anything?
- What would I do differently if I believed I was already loved?

Truth summary

> Love that must be earned is not the kind of love God gives. I am loved by God before I do anything. I can care for my parents and respect them without trying to purchase what should be freely given.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Love, By God
- Grace
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Parenting
- Salvation

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I have to earn my parents' love"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I have to earn my parents' love." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ When did I learn love had a price?
- ☐ What happened when I failed?
- ☐ What does God's love require?
- ☐ Who gives me love freely?
- ☐ What would I do if I knew I was loved?
- ☐ What can I do with no reward?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God's love is given, not earned.
- ☐ Christ died for me while I was still a sinner.
- ☐ I do not have to pay a debt I never owed.
- ☐ I love because He first loved me.
- ☐ Their conditions are not God's.
- ☐ I am loved before I do anything.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Romans 5:8
  "But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us."
- ☐ Ephesians 2:8–9
  "For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast."
- ☐ 1 John 4:19
  "We love because He first loved us."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Loved before doing: Each morning, say "I am loved before I do anything today," and note one task done from love, not fear.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Romans 5:8 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Christ loved me while I was still a sinner, so I do not have to earn love.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Grace" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Trace the price list. Write what you had to do to get approval as a child.
- [ ] Read Romans 5:8 slowly. Let it sink in that He loved you at your worst.
- [ ] Do something for no reward. Show kindness this week without expecting anything back.
- [ ] Share the story. Tell a trusted friend or counselor about the conditions you grew up with.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I have to earn my parents' love": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Loved before doing
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I have to earn my parents' love.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have worked for love all my life. Thank You that You loved me while I was still a sinner. Teach me to receive Your love as a gift and to stop paying for what You freely give. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.